

# 62 Jonathan

*The king's son who could have been jealous, and chose to be a friend.*

Jonathan was Saul's son and in line for Israel's throne. He was a brave soldier who trusted God enough to attack a Philistine garrison with only his armor-bearer beside him. When David killed Goliath and won the people's love, Jonathan had every reason to see him as a rival. Instead he made a covenant of friendship with him, gave him his own robe and weapons, and defended him before his angry father. He stayed loyal to both father and friend, and died beside Saul in battle.

## At a glance

|               |                                                                       |
|---------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Name          | Hebrew <i>Yehonatan</i> , "the LORD has given"                        |
| Family        | Son of Saul and Ahinoam; sisters Merab and Michal (1 Samuel 14:49–50) |
| Son           | Mephibosheth, or Merib-baal (2 Samuel 4:4; 1 Chronicles 8:34)         |
| When          | Saul's reign, c. 1050–1010 BC                                         |
| Key places    | Gibeah, Geba, Michmash, Ziph, Mount Gilboa                            |
| Key people    | Saul, David, his armor-bearer, Mephibosheth                           |
| New Testament | Not named                                                             |

*"And it came to pass, when he had made an end of speaking unto Saul, that the soul of Jonathan was knit with the soul of David, and Jonathan loved him as his own soul."*

1 Samuel 18:1, KJV

# The life of Jonathan

*Dates are approximate; Scripture does not give Jonathan's age.*

|                        |                                                                                                                                                                    |
|------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Early in Saul's reign  | ● <b>Strikes the garrison at Geba</b><br>Jonathan attacks a Philistine garrison at Geba, and the Philistines gather a vast army in reply. <i>1 Samuel 13:2-5</i>   |
| Early in Saul's reign  | ● <b>Climbs to Michmash</b><br>With only his armor-bearer, he climbs to a Philistine outpost, and panic spreads through the camp. <i>1 Samuel 14:1-23</i>          |
| The same day           | ● <b>Tastes the honey</b><br>Not knowing Saul's oath, he eats wild honey. The army rescues him from death. <i>1 Samuel 14:24-45</i>                                |
| After Goliath's defeat | ● <b>Makes a covenant</b><br>He loves David as his own soul, makes a covenant with him, and gives him his robe and weapons. <i>1 Samuel 18:1-4</i>                 |
| Saul's rage grows      | ● <b>Defends David</b><br>He speaks well of David to Saul. Later Saul throws a spear at him, and Jonathan warns David with arrows. <i>1 Samuel 19:1-7; 20:1-42</i> |
| David in hiding        | ● <b>The last meeting</b><br>In the wilderness of Ziph he strengthens David in God and says David will be king. <i>1 Samuel 23:15-18</i>                           |
| c. 1010 BC             | ● <b>Dies on Mount Gilboa</b><br>The Philistines kill Jonathan and two brothers; Saul dies the same day. <i>1 Samuel 31:1-13</i>                                   |
| Afterwards             | ● <b>Mourned and honored</b><br>David laments them in a song, and later shows kindness to Jonathan's son. <i>2 Samuel 1:17-27; 9:1-13; 21:12-14</i>                |

## Key activities

*Jonathan's love for David is a covenant friendship between two men pledged to each other before God. David's lament calls it "wonderful, passing the love of women" (2 Samuel 1:26), a way of speaking about the depth of their loyalty.*

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- 1 Led the first blow.** He struck the Philistine garrison at Geba, opening the war for Israel's freedom. *1 Samuel 13:3*

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  - 2 Trusted God against the odds.** He told his armor-bearer, "there is no restraint to the LORD to save by many or by few." *1 Samuel 14:6*

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  - 3 Asked God for a sign.** He agreed that if the Philistines said "Come up," they would go, and took it as the LORD's answer. *1 Samuel 14:8-12*

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  - 4 Spoke honestly about a bad order.** When he learned of the oath, he said, "My father hath troubled the land." *1 Samuel 14:27-30*

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  - 5 Bound himself to David.** He made a covenant with David and gave him the robe and weapons of a king's son. *1 Samuel 18:1-4*

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  - 6 Stood up for his friend.** He reminded Saul that David had risked his life and done Saul only good. *1 Samuel 19:1-7*

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  - 7 Kept watch and sent a warning.** He tested his father's mood at the new moon feast and warned David with arrows shot in the field. *1 Samuel 20:18-42*

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  - 8 Asked for kindness to his family.** He asked David to show kindness to his house for ever, and they swore, "The LORD be between me and thee, and between my seed and thy seed for ever." *1 Samuel 20:14-17, 42*

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  - 9 Strengthened David in God.** In the wilderness he "strengthened his hand in God" and told him, "thou shalt be king over Israel, and I shall be next unto thee." *1 Samuel 23:16-17*

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  - 10 Stayed by his father.** Though he knew David would be king, he fought beside Saul to the end. *1 Samuel 31:2*

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# Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Jonathan.

## Old Testament

|                             |                                                        |
|-----------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------|
| 1 Samuel 13–31              | The main account of his life                           |
| 2 Samuel 1:17–27            | David's lament: "in their death they were not divided" |
| 2 Samuel 4:4; 9:1–13        | David cares for Mephibosheth "for Jonathan's sake"     |
| 2 Samuel 21:7, 12–14        | David keeps his oath and buries Jonathan's bones       |
| 1 Chronicles 8:33–34; 10:2  | His family and his death at Gilboa                     |
| Echo: Proverbs 17:17; 18:24 | "A friend loveth at all times"                         |

## New Testament

|                  |                                          |
|------------------|------------------------------------------|
| Echo: John 15:13 | Laying down one's life for one's friends |
| Echo: John 3:30  | "He must increase, but I must decrease"  |

### For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did Jonathan give David when they made their covenant, and what did those gifts mean (1 Samuel 18:3–4)?
2. *Understand:* Jonathan stayed loyal to both Saul and David. How did he manage two loyalties that pulled against each other?
3. *Apply:* Jonathan "strengthened his hand in God." Who needs that kind of visit or message from you this week?
4. *Apply:* Is there someone whose gifts or success could make you feel threatened? What would it look like to act as Jonathan did toward them?